

Suggest and recommend

Teaching guide

Offer an idea using a natural verb pattern.

Understand the distinction

Use suggest or recommend with a noun or an -ing activity: suggest a cafe; recommend booking early. With a named person doing the action, a that clause is useful: I suggest that she book early. She should book is also possible after that, especially in British English.

Do not use suggest someone to do for advice. Say suggest that someone do, or suggest doing. Recommend has additional patterns and meanings, such as recommend someone for a job. Learn the meaning and pattern together instead of treating both verbs as identical in every use.

Compare the patterns

ACTIVITY

I recommend booking ahead.

Booking is the suggested activity.

PERSON + ACTION

I suggest that Mina call first.

Use the base verb call in this advice pattern.

RECIPIENT

She suggested a cafe to me.

To me identifies the recipient of the suggestion.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Correct this: She suggested me to apply.

2. Complete: I recommend ___ early. (arrive)

3. Is I suggest that she should call possible?

Use it in your own life

Suggest a practical action to a friend.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. She suggested that I apply.

Suggest does not use the person + to-infinitive advice pattern.

2. arriving

Use an -ing form for the activity.

3. Yes, especially in British English.

Should + base verb is an accepted alternative.

One possible response

I suggest taking an earlier train so you have time to find the office.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-17.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Suggest a practical action to a friend.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.